

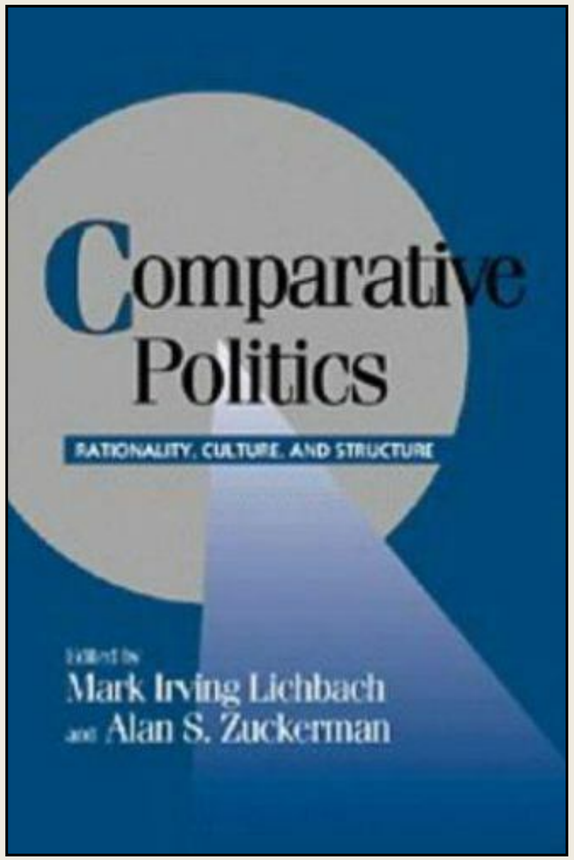
CITY UNIVERSITY OF HONG KONG, DEPARTMENT OF PUBLIC AND INTERNATIONAL AFFAIRS SEM A, A.Y. 2026/27

COMPARATIVE POLITICS AND SOCIETIES

PIA2050 | WEEK 3: IDENTITY AND INTER-GROUP CONFLICT

LAST WEEK

Last week we focused mostly on Lichbach and Zuckerman's (1997) discussion of the three main approaches or traditions in Comparative Politics:



* Structuralist;
* Culturalist;
* Rationalist.

Before we get into this week's material, it may be of some use to go over each of these approaches again (briefly) and recount their main strengths and weaknesses.

STRUCTURALISTS

STRUCTURALISTS IN A NUTSHELL:

A country's social and political organization is determined by material conditions (relations of production, class structure/inequality, technologies). Political systems change as a result of structural change.

STRENGTH OF THE APPROACH:

The recognition that history is made in circumstances beyond the control of any of the individual participants, who face in the prevailing "structures" crucial constraints.

WEAKNESS OF THE APPROACH:

Underestimates the role of individual agency; overstates "inevitability" of outcomes based on "structure."

CULTURALISTS

CULTURALISTS IN A NUTSHELL:

A country's social and political organization is determined by its culture (which influences rules/norms of politics as well as beliefs about political authority and institutions). Political systems change as a result of cultural change.

STRENGTH OF THE APPROACH:

"The logic of appropriateness" accounts for a great deal of individual behavior, as motivated by the desire to "fit in."

WEAKNESS OF THE APPROACH:

Understates "intentionality" of human behavior; overstates the "inevitability" of outcomes based on "culture." No mechanism for cultural change = no mechanism for social and political change.

RATIONALISTS

RATIONALISTS IN A NUTSHELL:

A country's social and political organization is determined by individuals pursuing their self-interest.

Specific outcomes hinge on whether and on how the leaders of organized groups ("political entrepreneurs") solve the "collective action problem."

STRENGTH OF THE APPROACH:

Its focus on individual agency and on the intentionality of human beings.

WEAKNESS OF THE APPROACH:

Incomplete view of people's motivations; unrealistic assumptions about the way people form their beliefs and make decisions.

POLITICAL DEVELOPMENT

The focus of today's class is the concept of "political development." In common parlance/discourse as well as in the social science literature, the word "development" has at least two different meanings:

(1) Development as progress (or, development as the process by which something becomes more advanced, or its potential is realized in some way): When we talk about "economic development," for instance, we generally mean the process by which an underdeveloped country (a poor, non-industrialized, backward country) becomes developed (wealthy, industrialized, technologically advanced)—e.g., the United Nations Development Program (UNDP) calculates the so-called "Human Development Index" on the basis of a nation's per capita income, life expectancy, and education.



A government of laws, and not men.

—John Adams, “Novanglus Papers, No. 7” (1859)

POLITICAL DEVELOPMENT

(2) Development as change:

The definition we adopt for this class today equates "development," not so much with "progress," but with change over time, in any direction.

On that basis, "political development" is defined as the process by which political systems change over time.

This is similar to the definitions of "political development" proposed by Samuel Huntington and more recently by Francis Fukuyama.

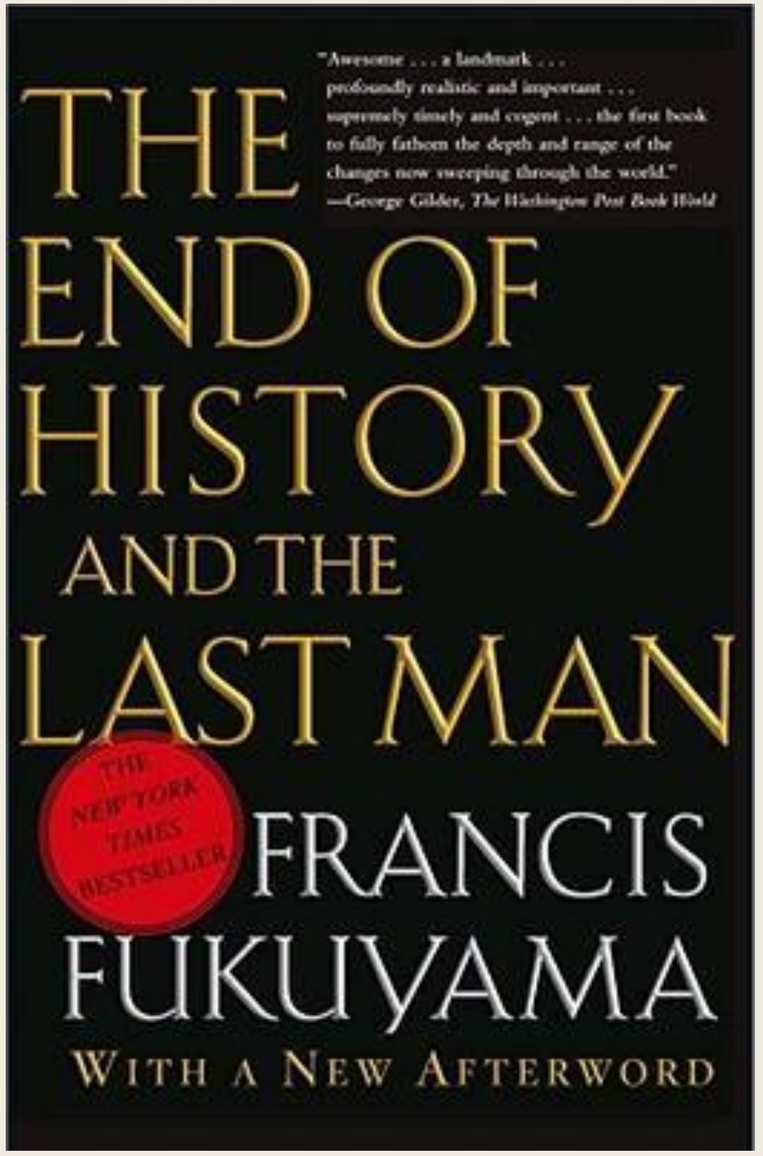
Their definitions are almost entirely focused on political institutions. For his part, Fukuyama (2014: 7, 23) defines it as the "change over time in political institutions" and "the process by which institutions emerge, evolve, and eventually decay."

A UNIVERSAL HISTORY?

Of particular interest to us today is whether we can identify a basic mechanism of political development—the "engine" of history. This is a big question that has been studied by some of the biggest names in the history of political thought.

This line of inquiry can be traced back to some of the original attempts to write what Fukuyama calls a "Universal History of Mankind."

In his book The End of History and the Last Man, Fukuyama attributes to "the German idealist tradition" some of the earliest efforts of this kind.

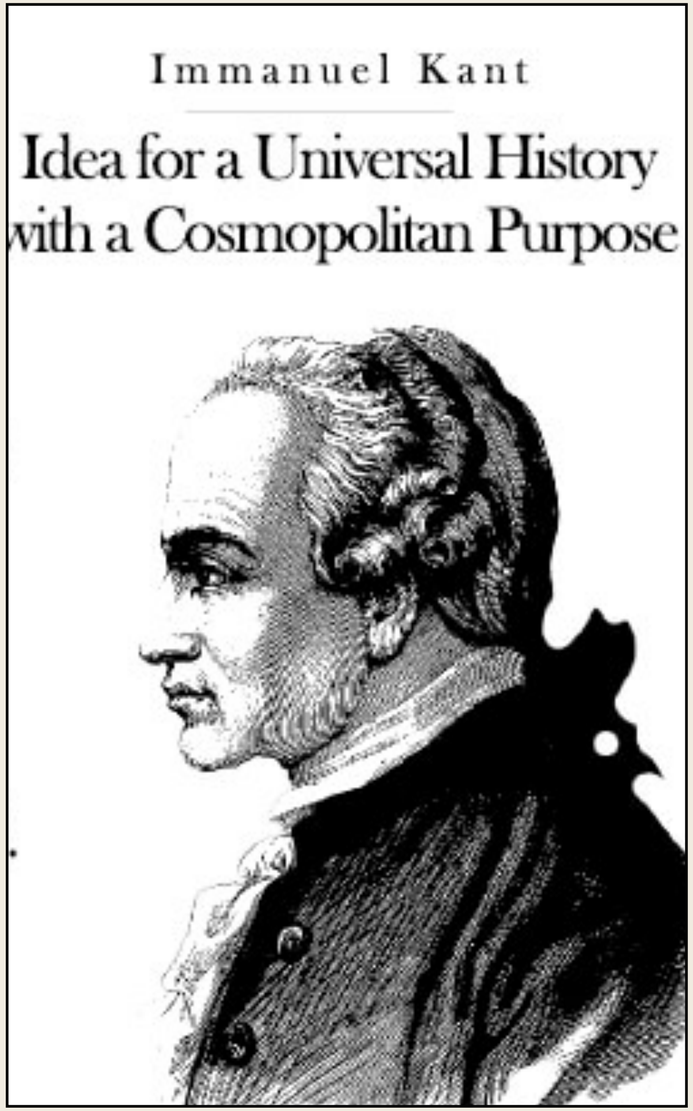


A UNIVERSAL HISTORY?

In 1784, Immanuel Kant wrote the essay "An Idea for a Universal History from a Cosmopolitan Point of View."

Kant examined the question of "whether, when taking all societies and all times into account, there was overall reason to expect general human progress in the direction of republican government" (Fukuyama 1992: 58).

Then again, Fukuyama (1992: 59) points out that Kant stopped short of attempting to write a Universal History.



A UNIVERSAL HISTORY?

The task was taken up by Georg Wilhelm Friedrich Hegel. According to Fukuyama (1992: 60), “Hegel saw progress in history as arising not from the steady development of reason, but through the blind interplay that led men to conflict, revolution, and war [...] History proceeds through a continual process of conflict, wherein systems of thought as well as political systems collide and fall apart from their own internal contradictions. They are then replaced by less contradictory and therefore higher ones, which give rise to new and different contradictions” (i.e., the “dialectic”).



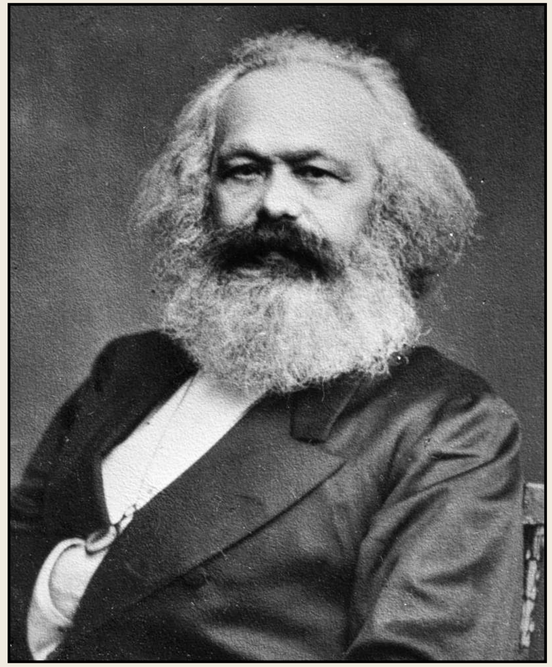
A UNIVERSAL HISTORY?

Fukuyama (1992: 62) writes that, in Hegel's thought, "Human history must therefore be seen not only as a succession of different civilizations and levels of material accomplishment, but more importantly as a succession of different forms of consciousness."

"Consciousness—the way in which human beings think about fundamental questions of right and wrong, the activities they find satisfying, their beliefs about the gods, even the way in which they perceive the world—has changed fundamentally over time."



A UNIVERSAL HISTORY?



Perhaps the most famous attempt to write a Universal History was made by Karl Marx, who adopted Hegel's dialectic method in the formulation of his "historical materialism." Marx borrowed from Hegel the idea that political/economic systems evolve thanks to a continual process of conflict that exposes the contradictions eventually responsible for their collapse and replacement.

In place of Hegel's idealism, however, Marx's dialectic is materialist in nature—conflict is assumed to revolve around the control of the means of production and the appropriation of economic surplus, while the "contradictions" responsible for the breakdown/replacement of economic and political systems are rooted in material conditions (e.g., crises of overproduction).

OUR FRAMEWORK

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CONCEPTUAL ANALYSIS article

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The microfoundations of political development: structure and agency in historical institutionalism

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OUR FRAMEWORK

The starting point in our efforts to put together a workable framework to understand how politics and history works is what I said at the end of last week's meeting regarding "an alternative" approach to the study of Comparative Politics:

(1) All collective behavior is the aggregate result of individual actions/decisions. Explanations in the social sciences should not only be based on realistic assumptions about individual behavior; they should be supported by mechanisms operating at the level of the individuals involved (so-called "microfoundations").

(2) Individuals often do not act according to the requirements of "instrumental rationality." Emotions may at times be strong enough to crowd out other considerations (like self-interest); even when emotional impulses are resistible, visceral cravings might block out the process of deliberation. Most behavior is driven by visceral factors in part, but is sensitive to costs and benefits.

OUR FRAMEWORK

(3) Still, intentional, goal-oriented behavior (that is, actions intended to produce a certain effect or realize a certain goal) can be interpreted/explained by uncovering the motivations and the beliefs of the agents; explanations in the social sciences should feature an attempt to establish the beliefs and motives of individuals.

Elster (2007), in particular, suggests that our attempts to explain any outcome in the social sciences take the following form:

(i) Explain why the individuals responsible for the outcome behave as they do, focusing on desires (what one wants to achieve) and beliefs (particularly with regard to aspects of reality that help predict the behavior of others and the effects of one's own actions) as well as their causes (possibly including structure/culture);

(ii) Explain how individual actions combine to produce the outcome in question.

UNDERSTANDING POLITICS

Politics is largely about the competition between organized, collective actors or groups; the fight typically revolves around the distribution of power and material resources, or competing visions of the way a society should work.

Understanding politics therefore requires that we understand how competing groups are constituted as well as both their internal functioning and their interactions with each other.

Until fairly recently, students/observers of politics treated the issue of how competing organized groups come about as fairly straightforward and unproblematic, assuming organizations would arise whenever some large number of people had some shared interest. Olson's The Logic of Collective Action (1965) challenged this assumption, but failed to provide a satisfactory solution to the "collective action problem."

COLLECTIVE ACTION

So what is the solution to the "collective action problem?" This question forces us to consider common individual motives beyond self-interest. Three other kinds of motivations are at play:

(1) Human beings are animated by passions or emotions (anger, resentment, fear, guilt, shame) that serve as impulses to act with less regard for the consequences.

More importantly, people care a great deal about their self-image and their public image, so they often act out of a need/desire for reassurance of their self-worth and social standing—typically by adopting behavior that "fits in" with others (esp. the other members of groups that are important to our sense of identity), in other situations by differentiating themselves from others.

All this can lead people to think in ways that are not very rational and act in ways that contradict (or disregard) self-interest.

COLLECTIVE ACTION

(2) Human beings are, in David Beetham's (1991) words, "moral agents" who have "some notion of the common interest, and acknowledge the binding force of promises they have made"—i.e., they tend to do what they think is right even if it doesn't serve their self-interest. Note that this isn't always a good thing.

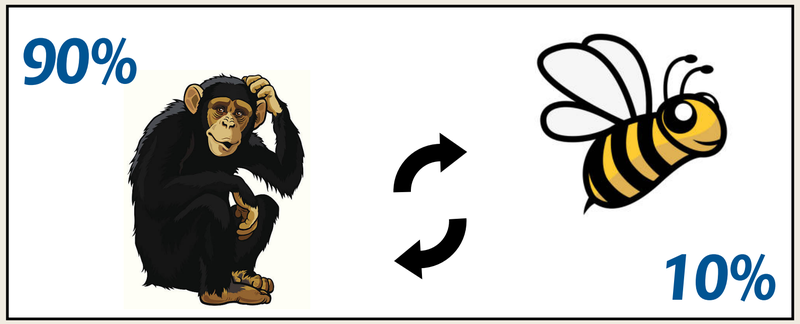
(3) Human beings have a natural impulse to engage in "self-categorization" (i.e., think of ourselves and others in terms of group membership) and practice "parochial altruism" (i.e., favor people, even unknown people, seen as members of the same group, while discriminating against others).

For more on the psychology of "self-categorization," "parochial altruism," and "social identity theory," let's watch this video:

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=mBDULN6Jtn0

COLLECTIVE ACTION

"Parochial altruism," especially when combined with the desire to uphold our self-image and/or public reputation, renders us capable of great sacrifices when it comes to advancing perceived interests of "our" groups and great savagery when it comes to defending "our" groups from a perceived external threat (note that perception of interests/threat can be manipulated).



The link between altruism/aggression is well known:
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=XoTx7Rt4dig

Jonathan Haidt calls this the "Hive Switch," noting people are "90% Chimp, 10% Bee" — most of our lives are taken up by petty concerns; under some conditions, however, we have an ability to "lose ourselves in something larger," where the self tends to disappear and collective interests dominate. Even in our daily lives, we are often "nagged" by a sense that there is some higher or nobler (collective) purpose out there for us.

COLLECTIVE ACTION

"Social categorization" and "parochial altruism" have as strong an impact on people's beliefs as they have on people's motivations.

Haidt (2012: xxxiii) writes: "People bind themselves into political teams that share moral narratives. Once they accept a particular narrative, they become blind to alternative moral worlds."

"Morality," as Haidt puts it, "binds and blinds," because the moral beliefs we hold, as important as they are to the cohesiveness of our social groups, drive our perceptions of reality, blind us to disconfirming evidence and logic, and lead us into making snap judgments we are subsequently driven to rationalize.

Though it often comes at the cost of deceiving ourselves, this rationalization helps us earn some reassurance of our "beneffactance"—i.e., the notion that "I am nice and in control" (see Pinker 1999: 423).

COLLECTIVE ACTION

The key point, for our purposes, is that the "desires" and "beliefs" that drive individual action are to some extent "endogenous" to the process of mobilization—meaning, they can be shaped by what leaders/organizations do in an effort to maximize individual participation in collective action.

Individuals targeted for mobilization in a group or movement have pre-existing, "exogenous" desires and beliefs (exogenous means "having external causes"). However, the activities in which a group engages (use of rhetoric, narratives, symbols, rituals, etc.) can re-shape an individual's pre-existing desires and beliefs, thereby changing his/her predisposition for action.

Social or collective identities are the sources of solidarities, values, and self-images, whose affirmation can motivate action—e.g., "I do this because this is who I am" or "I do this to defend my sense of dignity" or "I do this to earn the recognition I/we deserve."

INTER-GROUP CONFLICT

So, to recap, "inter-group conflict" is the engine of political development/history. For the most part, moreover, "inter-group conflict," is rooted in two key characteristics of human nature:

(i) The "groupishness" of human beings, complete with a tendency to engage in "social categorization" in order to define our own place in society, develop strong emotional attachments to our social groups, adopt markers that signal group affiliation, rely on social identities for self-evaluation, and practice "parochial altruism;"

(ii) The human propensity for "status-seeking behavior" rooted in basic desires for subjective well-being, for control of one's social environment, for self-esteem, and for the approval of others—all of which have an evolutionary basis.

INTER-GROUP CONFLICT

These two characteristics account for the fact that inter-group conflict often takes the form of a struggle for "inter-subjective recognition"—struggles waged by groups for the purpose of getting others (or society as a whole) to recognize their status as equal (or superior) to other groups; more precisely, the goal is typically to change the treatment that a society's laws/policies reserve for different groups depending on the status accorded to them.

Perhaps most famously, Fukuyama (1992) ascribes to inter-group struggles over "inter-subjective recognition" a crucial role in the progression of human history. Fukuyama defines "recognition" as "an intersubjective state of mind by which one human being acknowledges the worth or status of another human being, or of that human being's gods, customs, and beliefs." We can hear it directly from him: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=H8Dbs6LEYzM (from 9:50 onwards).

INTER-GROUP CONFLICT

In Fukuyama's (1992: 144-5) own words, "the struggle for recognition" is "the centerpiece" of a "non-materialist historical dialectic that is much richer in its understanding of human motivation than the Marxist version."

Why "richer?" Because it accounts for "the prideful and assertive side of human nature that is responsible for driving most wars and political conflicts," contemplates that conflict can be driven by ideas and, especially, identities.

Fukuyama (2011: 41) proposed more recently that "a great deal of contemporary politics revolves around demands for recognition particularly on the part of groups that have historical reasons for believing their worth has not been adequately acknowledged." Such demands may have an "economic component," but "economic resources" are often "markers of dignity rather than ends in themselves."

SOCIAL IDENTITY THEORY

The workings of hierarchical systems and the presence of inequality account for the potential for a “struggles for recognition” to break out.

However, the proponents of “Social Identity Theory” have long pointed out that members of subordinate groups can challenge existing status hierarchies only to the extent that they are capable of imagining “cognitive alternatives” to the status quo.

Consequently, organized challenges to the status quo become more likely when the situation becomes unstable and illegitimate, sometimes as a result of an actual decrease in the “objective deprivation” of subordinates.

Conversely, the avoidance of conflict requires a “consensually accepted status system” or a “status system” that is “sufficiently firm and pervasive to prevent the creation of cognitive alternatives to it” (see Tajfel and Turner 1986: 12).

SOCIAL IDENTITY THEORY

Aside from the fact that inter-group comparisons become more plausible when inter-group differences are reduced, the phenomenon sometimes referred to as the "revolution of rising expectations" is consistent with what has been described as a "general rule" of "motivation theory," according to which "getting begets wanting."

Once they break out, struggles over recognition tend to be especially intractable when compared to other forms of conflict, thereby confirming the conventional wisdom that conflicts over identity are inherently nastier and harder to solve.

As Fukuyama (2011: 41) pointed out, the relational value of status (the value of one's status depends on the status of others) makes "the struggle for recognition" inherently zero-sum, for "one person's recognition can come only at the expense of the dignity of someone else."

SOCIAL IDENTITY THEORY

What is worse, recent work suggests that insofar as individuals value (and fear) losses far more than they value (and covet) equivalent gains, the preference to maintain the status quo held by members of challenged dominant groups should be more intense than the preference for change held by the members of subordinate groups.

Indeed, Social Identity Theory predicts that groups whose superiority is challenged will often "react in an intensely discriminatory fashion" (see Tajfel and Turner 1986: 22) and redouble their efforts to defend the status quo.

Roy Baumeister's (1996) famous study of "evil" revealed that some of the worst episodes of violence tend to be the result of "threatened egotism"—violence, that is, is perpetrated as a reaction to a threat leveled (generally from below) against the self-image of someone with a high (as opposed to a low) opinion of him-/herself.

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